

Milestone 1: Childcare Price Analysis

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Summary of Analysis

The dataset analyzed for this project is the National Database of Childcare Prices, which provides county-level estimates of weekly childcare prices across the United States. The data includes prices by child age group (infant, toddler, preschool, and school-age), provider type (center-based and family-based care), and year. I reviewed the accompanying technical guide to understand how prices were calculated, including the use of survey data and imputed values where direct data was unavailable.

Initial analysis focused on understanding how childcare prices vary by age group and location, and how those prices compare conceptually to what working families may expect to afford. I explored average weekly prices across counties, differences between infant care and school-age care, and general geographic variability. The analysis was performed using exploratory summaries and basic comparisons, as the goal of Milestone 1 is to understand and plan rather than to finalize storytelling.

Findings

Several patterns stand out from the initial analysis. Infant and toddler care are consistently the most expensive forms of childcare, often costing significantly more than preschool or school-age care. Center-based care is generally more expensive than family-based care, though the price gap varies widely by county. Prices also differ substantially across geographic areas, meaning that families with similar incomes may face very different childcare burdens depending on where they live.

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Another important observation is that weekly childcare costs can represent a significant portion of a working parent's income, especially for families with more than one child under the age of 10. Even before factoring in housing, food, or healthcare, childcare alone can consume a meaningful share of household earnings.

Assumptions

My analysis assumes that weekly childcare prices reasonably represent full-time childcare costs for working parents. It also assumes that county-level averages are a valid proxy for what families experience locally, even though actual prices may vary by provider. Additionally, imputed values in the dataset are treated as valid estimates, as described in the technical guide, though they may not reflect every individual family's situation.

Items That Still Need Clarification

Some questions remain unanswered at this stage. The dataset does not show availability of childcare slots, only prices, which limits insight into access versus affordability. It also does not capture informal childcare arrangements, such as care provided by relatives or friends. Finally, household income is not included directly, so comparisons between childcare prices and family earnings will require additional data or careful framing in later milestones.

Direction of Story

The story will focus on helping working parents understand how childcare costs change as children age and how those costs differ by location. The goal is to make

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childcare pricing more transparent, allowing parents better to plan work decisions, budget, and childcare transitions. The message will emphasize that childcare affordability is a structural challenge faced by many working families. The call to action will encourage parents to use data when advocating for employer flexibility, childcare support programs, or local policy changes.

Target Audience

The primary audience is working parents with children aged 10 or younger. This group may not be familiar with childcare pricing data or statistical analysis, so the communication will avoid technical jargon and focus on practical implications. As a presenter, I will position myself as someone who interprets public data to help parents make informed decisions, rather than as a policy expert.

Media to Be Used

- **Interactive Dashboard** – A simple, parent-friendly dashboard showing childcare prices by child age and county, allowing parents to explore costs relevant to their situation.
- **Infographic** – A one-page visual explaining how childcare costs typically change from infancy through school age.
- **Short Explainer Presentation** – A brief PowerPoint Presentation summarizing key takeaways and what they mean for working parents balancing childcare and employment.